

Jalapeño-Spiked Cherry Preserves

2 cups sugar

1 ½ cups water

2/3 cup cider vinegar

1 ½ teaspoons ground ginger

½ teaspoon ground cinnamon

Dash of salt

Dash of ground cloves

Dash of ground nutmeg

4 jalapeño peppers, coarsely chopped

2 pounds sweet cherries, pitted and coarsely chopped

1 large Granny Smith apple, cored and chopped

Combine all ingredients in a large, heavy saucepan, bring to a boil. Reduce heat, and simmer until slightly thick and reduced to about 5 cups (1-2 hours), skimming foam from surface of mixture occasionally, if necessary. Cool; pour into an airtight container. Mixture will thicken as it cools. Cover and chill.

NOTES:

Be sure to use seeds from the jalapeño peppers to infuse the preserves with some heat.

Refrigerate preserves in an airtight container for up to three weeks. May also be frozen.

Cherry season is late May to early August

Serve as a condiment with toast, as a sandwich spread with smoked turkey, as a sauce for grilled or blackened chicken or pork chops, or as an appetizer topping with cream cheese and crackers.